



THOSE WHO TOILED KNEW NOTHING OF THE DREAMS OF THOSE WHO PLANNED

METROPOLIS / 1927

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Science fiction

DIRECTOR

Fritz Lang

WRITERS

**Fritz Lang,
Thea von Harbou**

STARS

**Alfred Abel, Gustav
Fröhlich, Rudolf Klein-
Rogge, Brigitte Helm**

BEFORE

1922 With *Dr. Mabuse the Gambler*, Lang and von Harbou introduce the arch-criminal to the big screen for first time.

1924 *The Nibelungs* is

Lang and von Harbou's epic two-part silent fantasy.

AFTER

1929 *Woman in the Moon* is Lang's next science-fiction masterpiece after *Metropolis*.

1931 *M* stands for "Murderer" in Lang and von Harbou's desolate thriller.



Many movies have journeyed into the future, and most of them owe a debt to Fritz Lang's *Metropolis*.

Made in Germany in 1927, this tale of city life projects itself a hundred years ahead of its time.

Mirror image

Metropolis is set in 2026, but it is really a warped reflection of the era in which it was made. In its striking black-and-white imagery, influenced by German Expressionism, lie the nightmares of a world in flux. The mechanized horrors of World War I were fresh in the memory, and the Nazis would soon begin their rise to power, proposing totalitarian solutions to Germany's problems.

Lang's vision of the cityscape of the future was heavily influenced by the skyscrapers that were being built at the time in New York.

Lang often said that the idea for *Metropolis* came to him on a visit to New York in 1924, and it shows. The American city, with its soaring skyscrapers and views of ant-sized citizens, clearly inspired the first science-fiction cityscape ever shown on screen. Lang worked with visual-effects pioneer Eugen Schüfftan to create an exaggerated version of Manhattan, combining models of monorails and shining pinnacles with vast clockwork sets, in which the humans operating the machines are little more than cogs.